

Q. Who is India's No. 1 male stand-up comedian?

1 KAPIL SHARMA **38.1** [38]



2 ZAKIR KHAN **10.8** [10.7]



3 SUNIL GROVER **9.8** [9.1]



4 VARUN THAKUR **5.7** [5.7]



5 ANUBHAV SINGH BASSI **5.2** [6.3]

Q. Who is India's No. 1 female stand-up comedian?



1 BHARTI SINGH **39.6** [37.1]



2 MALLIKA DUA **7** [9.2]



4 JEEYA SETHI **6.5** [7.6]



3 SUGANDHA MISHRA **7** [8.3]



5 SHREEJA CHATURVEDI **6** [7.2]

All figures in %; rest, others; Aug. '24 figures in bold, Feb. '24 in [ ]

Q. What do you think of the high-profile wedding of Anant Ambani and Radhika Merchant?

It will promote India as a global wedding destination	**4.1%**
It will establish India firmly on the global luxury map	**6.7%**
It was a smart global PR exercise for Reliance and the Ambanis	**4.4%**
They have wealth, so they have celebrated. It's perfectly fine and personal	**35.9%**
It was an ostentatious display of wealth	**30.1%**
Don't know/ can't say	**18.9%**

ticularly having lost his box office sheen. The anticipation for *Pushpa 2: The Rule* ensures that the National Award-winning Telugu star Allu Arjun is part of the conversation. In fact, he is the only actor from the South to feature in the top five.

Among actresses, Deepika Padukone solidified her supremacy, riding high on the success of two big-ticket action dramas, *Fighter* and *Kalki 2898 AD*. She has been the go-to ambassador for Indian cinema abroad for the past few years; 2024 saw her appearance at the BAFTAs make headlines. With a baby due next month, she will be missing from the big screen for a few months, but expect her to make a comeback, much like Alia Bhatt, who finished at No. 3. A distant second is Katrina Kaif, whose January release *Merry Christmas* showed an artiste who is eager to experiment and display her thespian skills. Rashmika Mandanna, better known as the Srivalli from *Pushpa*, took the fourth slot. Anushka Sharma rounded the top five, thereby proving that regular appearances in cricket matches make up for the lack of film releases to remain in the public consciousness.

What binds the stars together, interestingly, is how pretty much all of them were prominent faces at the wedding festivities of Anant Ambani and Radhika Merchant, which dominated the headlines for a sizeable chunk of 2024. Nearly 36 per cent of the MOTN respondents found it "perfectly fine" for the Ambanis to go all-out to celebrate the nuptials of their youngest child while 30.1 per cent said that it was nothing but "an ostentatious display of wealth".

Meanwhile, OTT platforms have made household names of the likes of Pankaj Tripathi, who goes by Kaleen Bhaiyya of *Mirzapur*, and Manoj Bajpayee, whose Srikant Tiwari from *The Family Man* is much beloved. The two are followed by Abhishek Bachchan, Bobby Deol and Nawazuddin Siddiqui, who were amongst the first actors to jump on the streaming bandwagon. Meanwhile, Sushmita Sen continues to be OTT queen with her gutsy acts in *Aarya* and *Taali*. Raveena Tandon's packed 2024 roster—web series *Karmma Calling* and two direct-to-digital features—paid off with her ranking second.

When it comes to tickling the funny bone, the respondents stuck to the usual, familiar suspects. Kapil Sharma may have switched from TV to streaming (Netflix), but his audience has stuck with him. Filling his giant shoes on Sony is stand-up comic Zakir Khan with his own variety show, *Aapka Apna Zakir*. They are followed by Kapil's old collaborator Sunil Grover. Meanwhile, Bharti Singh, Mallika Dua and Sugandha Mishra were chosen as the go-to laughter queens. ■